



PHOTO BY **HARDIK CHHABRA**

readings. Sustained exposure to wet bulb temperature readings, even quite a bit below 'normal' body temperature of 37°C, can cause excess heat retention, and ultimately organ damage.

This manifests not just in acute events like heat stroke, but in a chronic and gradual sapping of human possibility with huge economic and social costs. The ILO estimated \$2.4 trillion in GDP losses in 2019,

and reports that today 70% of the global workforce is exposed to heat at work.

Sadly, large swathes of the Indo-Gangetic plains endure extended periods when such heat stress is likely visited upon millions of Indians. Even with the advent of welcome cooling from the monsoon, often wet bulb temperatures remain high enough that heat stress isn't easily alleviated even then.

Given the ubiquity and likely increasing severity of the heat problem, and the lack of easily accessed funding, I suggest a three-part approach to understand the progress we've made in India, and the distance left to go, in addressing it—awareness, information, and experimentation. Here, I'll confine myself to illustrating what I mean by each of these elements.

Awareness: Heat has entered the policy lexicon. The National Action Plan on Climate Change of the Ministry of Environment, Forest and Climate Change will surely address it. Several Indian cities are announcing Heat Action Plans. But societal awareness is as yet work-in-progress. A year ago, the National Foundation for India in Delhi led a team, including some researchers at Harvard's Mittal Institute, to create a 'musical video short' explaining the consequences of heat stress after sustained heat waves swept the northern Indian plains in the summer of 2023. It's catchy, almost amusing, and replete with colour and panache. It fires the imagination. This is the kind of thing we need as much as speeches, opinion pieces (including this